



Ultrabooks

Ultrabooks started off as a very confused segment this year. Intel did eventually come out with strict criterion for the definition, but we did see plenty of decidedly chunky laptops wearing the "Ultrabook" tag with some degree of smugness.

Discrepancies with weight and thickness aside. We also saw ultrabooks that were attempting to morph into tablets, devices such as the IdeaPad Yoga 13, which could contort themselves in the most disturbing fashion. The ergonomics of such devices was hit and miss though. Ultimately, once the definition settled and we saw some more traditional designs making a come back, we ran into some very interesting devices that piqued our interest.

While they have not won any awards here, the Asus VivoBook S500C and the Samsung Series 5 Ultra Touch (NP-540U3C) were extremely impressive ultrabooks. Priced somewhat within the affordable price bands, they offered a blend of very good build quality, consistently good performance and the traditional slim-and-light ultrabook experience you would expect. Now, if these amazing ultrabooks did not win any awards, just imagine what the winners will be like

Zero1 Winner Aspire S7 - 392

The S7 is very expensive, but it's very obvious that Acer can actually make a good ultrabook if they put their minds to it. The all aluminum unibody chassis is extremely slim, and weighs in at just 1.3kg. Add to



Sony VAIO Pro 13

Price: ₹84,000



HP Envy TouchSmart Ultrabook 4-1113tu

Price: ₹65,000

that, something very rarely seen on a laptop till date - a Gorilla Glass 2 layer on the lid, over the white enamel finish. If this doesn't scream stylish, nothing probably will. We will not be pedantic for a while and draw your attention to the fact that this finish needs a lot of care (oops, we just did). But instead, we'll draw your attention to the rather powerful Intel Core i5-4200 @ 1.6GHz processor, from Intel's latest Haswell series. With 4GB of RAM and a very fast Kingston SMSR150S3256G solid state drive, this machine has clocked by far the better system and graphics benchmarks than any of the immediate rivals. Little things make all the difference, and the backlit keyboard with ambient control is again something not seen in many ultrabooks. The 13.3-inch display has a 1920 x 1080 pixel resolution. The keyboard is the only little niggle that we could find because the unusual decision to go with five rows instead of six can be ergonomically jarring.

Notable Mentions

Sony VAIO Pro 13

Others may claim otherwise, but for us, the Sony Vaio Pro 13 was the first ultrabook running the Intel Core i5-4200U Haswell processor, to be available in the market. The chassis is made from carbon fibre, and the sharp design makes this a looker. Little ergonomic goodies include a keyboard that has a slight elevation towards the back, because of the overall thickness spread, making typing a bit more fun. The Full HD display, extremely good battery life and the latest generation processor put this laptop very close to the top of the benchmark charts. This ultrabook is available in an i7 variant as well, for those who want more power. This is a lovely, sleek and powerful device and an ultrabook in the true sense of the word.

HP Envy TouchSmart Ultrabook 4-1113tu

While the TouchSmart Ultrabook 4-1113tu isn't the slimmest in this category, we need to appreciate and recognize the fact that the latest generation Intel Core i5-4200U processor does make this a good machine to consider, if you're looking at a purchase to last you at least a couple of years. The system held its own in all our tests and that, coupled with the six hours of battery life make this a highly recommended ultrabook any day. As expected, the keyboard is easily among the best we've seen, coming from HP. The build quality would feel right at home on a more expensive laptop. This is a more affordable laptop than the others here. but don't let the price fool you. It's one hell of a deal.



ASPIRE S7 - 392

Price: ₹1,05,000